CINEMA

A Knockout Punch from Kerala

ALAPPUZHA GYMKHANA lands a surprise hit, spotlighting small-town dreams and team spirit



Malayalam cinema has once again pushed an unassuming underdog up the box-office rankings in a year of big-star blockbusters. Amid thumping successes like Vicky Kaushal's *Chhaava*, Mohanlal's *L2: Empuraan* and Ajith Kumar's *Good Bad Ugly*, director Khalid Rahman's modestly-budgeted boxing film *Alappuzha Gymkhana*, featuring the cub *Premalu* star Naslen, has reportedly earned a gross worldwide figure of close to Rs 60 crore.

It's a repeat performance of last year's *Manjummel Boys*, another unexpected superhit from Kerala, which also featured an ensemble cast of young men. While both films are about young men working together closely for a common goal, they also share with Malayalam hits like *Angamaly Diaries* (2017) and *Kumbalangi Nights* (2019), a focus on a hyperlocal community, reflected in the names of Kerala villages and towns in the titles.

Alappuzha Gymkhana tracks a group of friends who fail their 12th-grade exams and decide to learn boxing to get through to college under the sports quota. The film opens by introducing the bunch of goofy teens as failures, and they remain so through the course of the movie. Yes, this is not an inspirational sports movie. It is a coming-of-age film, where the boys, initially unserious about boxing, slowly realise the need to work hard towards a goal and prove themselves.

SWEAT STORY Naslen with his co-stars in this still from the movie

But the proving doesn't happen. This movie is about the journey, not the destination. It does not move from plot beat A to B via C, but is a collage of goofy scenes that never threaten to get ponderous or dark. And while the film appears to be led by Naslen as Jojo, his co-actors (Ganapathi, Sandeep Pradeep, Shon Joy, Lukman Avaran and more) get ample meat to emerge as memorable characters—a true team effort befitting a sports film. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

THE LISTICLE

Upcoming Indian releases, theatrical and OTT, to watch out for

MAY 30 | *Theatres*

Kingdom

Vijay Deverakonda stars in this Telugu action film with a premise presumably set on the refugee crisis borne from the post-Independence Sinhala-Tamil conflict. Gowtam Tinnanuri, writer-director of the Telugu cricket-based hit *Jersey*, directs the film. Tamil hitmaker Anirudh Ravichander is the music director.



